ON FRIDAY MORNING, OCTOBER 19, BEFORE FLYING OFF TO Illinois, John Kennedy met with the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Except for their chairman, General Taylor, they had been excluded from Kennedy's advisory group on the Cuban crisis and were holding meetings of their own. Ever since the Bay of Pigs disaster, they had been advocating the idea of going back to Cuba in full force. The discovery of the Soviet SAMs and, later, MRBMs, and now the launch sites of IRBMs, was a godsend to the chiefs: in their eyes, the placement of Soviet missiles in Cuba made an invasion absolutely necessary. But the signals they were getting from Taylor and McNamara, who had taken part in the deliberations with the president, were more than worrisome: invasion was not high on the president's agenda. The long-awaited meeting with the president presented the chiefs with an opportunity to get him on their side.

Kennedy began the meeting with a discussion of the difficult choice with which the Soviet action presented him. "If we do nothing, they have a missile base there," said Kennedy, knowing perfectly well that that option was not acceptable to the generals. "If we attack Cuba, the missiles, or Cuba in any way, then it gives them a clear line to take Berlin," continued Kennedy. A few minutes into his presentation, he commented on the loss of Berlin: "Which leaves me the only one alternative, which is to fire nuclear weapons—which is a hell of an alternative." He sounded more positive on the blockade but saw a problem there as well: the Soviets could start a blockade of Berlin, blaming him for creating a crisis and alienating American allies in Europe. "So I don't think we've got any satisfactory alternatives," concluded Kennedy. "When we balance off that our problem is not merely Cuba, but it is also Berlin."[14]

The chiefs knew that a blockade was emerging as the preferable course of action among the president's advisers and decided to change tactics, remaining silent on outright invasion and advocating instead an all-out air strike at the Soviet installations. They hoped it would lead to invasion one way or another. The charge was led by General Curtis LeMay, the Air Force chief of staff, a tough-speaking and hard-driving officer who had commanded the firebombing of Tokyo in March 1945, overseen the Berlin airlift in 1948–49, and masterminded the creation of the US Strategic Air Command's capability to deliver nuclear weapons. He argued against a